



THEMIS

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES
FRACTIONAL CFO & NON-EXECUTIVE ADVISORY

WHAT EXIT READINESS ACTUALLY INVOLVES

Buyers don't pay for potential. They pay for evidence — and they start collecting it long before you do.

THE THREE THINGS THAT MOVE THE PRICE

01 THE EIGHTEEN-MONTH RUNWAY

- **Months 18–12.** Fix what a buyer would discount: margin leakage, loss-making lines, one-offs sitting in run-rate.
- **Months 12–6.** Two clean filed years, a monthly pack that ties to them, and a forecast you can defend line by line.
- **Months 6–0.** Data room, advisers, tax structuring — and a team that can run it while you sell it.
- **Work back from your filing dates.** A weak year inside the last two costs more than a strong year gains.

WHY IT MATTERS

EBITDA is bought on trailing performance. Improvements made after the process starts land in the buyer's numbers, not your price.

02 DILIGENCE HYGIENE

- **Reconciled to the pound.** Stock, WIP, accruals, intercompany, director loans — no unexplained residuals.
- **Contracts signed and on file.** Customers, suppliers, leases, IP, employment, and anything with a change-of-control clause.
- **Statutory house in order.** Filings current, share register clean, options and consents documented.
- **One version of the numbers.** Management accounts that bridge to the accounts, with the bridge written down.

WHY IT MATTERS

Every question you can't answer quickly becomes a price chip, an indemnity, or money held back in retention.

03 THE EQUITY STORY

- **What is actually being bought.** Recurring revenue, defensible margin, and headroom the buyer can see.
- **A three-year plan already part-delivered.** Year one substantially banked before anyone reads it.
- **Growth the buyer can execute.** Geography, capacity, cross-sell — not growth that depends on the founder.
- **Normalised EBITDA that survives challenge.** Add-backs evidenced, not asserted.

WHY IT MATTERS

Price is arithmetic. The multiple is a judgement about risk and future — and the story is what moves it.

WHAT ELSE GETS TESTED

Customer concentration

Top five as a share of revenue — and the contractual basis sitting under it.

Owner dependency

What breaks in the week after completion if you stop answering the phone.

Working capital

The normal level, agreed before the SPA — not argued about afterwards.

Management depth

A second line that stays, and is incentivised to stay through earn-out.

WHAT NOBODY SAYS OUT LOUD

Readiness isn't a document.

It's the condition of the business. The data room is the last five per cent — **the other ninety-five is trading history** you can no longer change.

The price is largely set before the process starts.

By the time the information memorandum is written, **the numbers it describes have already happened.**

Most founders start too late.

Twelve weeks isn't preparation — it's tidying. **The value is created in the eighteen months nobody wants to spend.**

**GET READY EIGHTEEN MONTHS EARLY,
OR NEGOTIATE THE DIFFERENCE LATER.**

RICHARD COOKE

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